Calicut University Four Year Undergraduate Programme (CUFYUGP)

English Language Skills for Humanities and Other BA Programmes

ENG1FA101(1B)

Module III
Reading

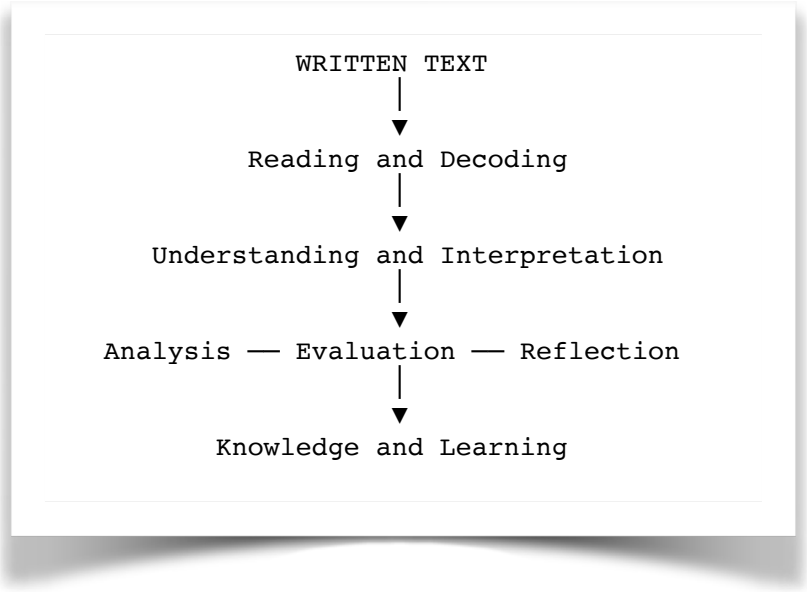
Introduction

What is Reading?

Reading is one of the four fundamental language skills, alongside listening, speaking, and writing. It is an essential means of communication and plays a significant role in education, personal development, and everyday life. Reading involves understanding, interpreting, and responding to written texts. However, it is much more than simply recognizing words on a page. Effective reading requires the reader to actively engage with the text by connecting new information with prior knowledge, making predictions, drawing conclusions, and evaluating ideas.

Reading is therefore an **active cognitive process** rather than a passive one. As a reader moves through a text, s/he continuously constructs meaning by interpreting words, phrases, sentences, and larger ideas. Successful reading demands concentration, vocabulary knowledge, language proficiency, and critical thinking. Through reading, people gain information, expand their understanding of the world, solve problems, communicate effectively, and enjoy literature.

Figure 1.1: Reading as an Active Process



Why Do We Read?

People read for many different reasons, and the purpose of reading often determines the way in which a text is approached. Understanding why we read helps us choose the most appropriate reading strategy.

Reading for Information

One of the primary reasons for reading is to acquire knowledge. Students read textbooks, newspapers, journals, magazines, research articles, and online resources to learn about different subjects. Reading for information helps individuals stay informed about current events, scientific discoveries, technological developments, and social issues. In academic settings, this type of reading forms the foundation of learning.

Reading for Communication

Reading also enables communication. Every day, people read emails, text messages, letters, notices, social media posts, and official documents. Such reading allows individuals to exchange ideas, understand others, and participate effectively in personal, professional, and academic interactions.

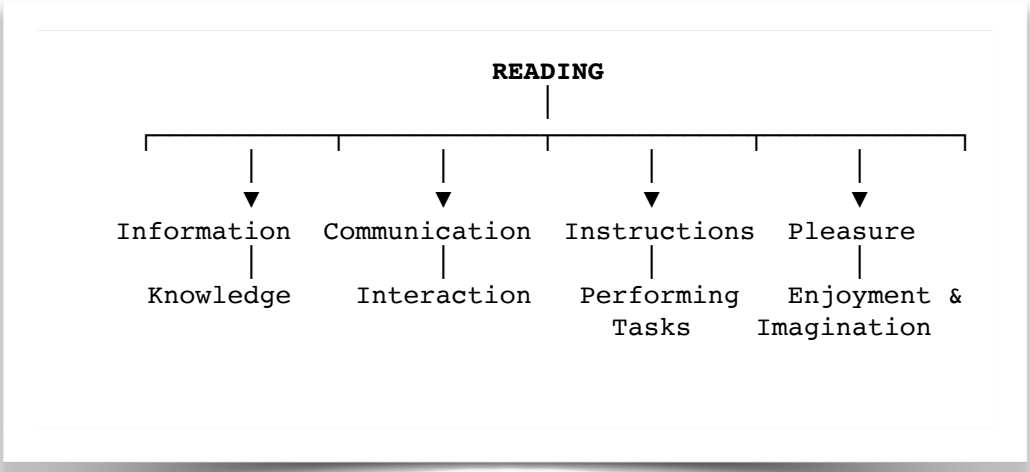
Reading for Instructions

Many situations require us to read instructions carefully before performing a task. User manuals, recipes, safety guidelines, examination instructions, and technical documents provide step-by-step directions that help people carry out activities accurately and safely. Careful reading is especially important when misunderstanding instructions can lead to mistakes or accidents.

Reading for Pleasure

Not all reading is done for work or study. Many people read novels, short stories, poems, comics, magazines, and travel literature simply because they enjoy doing so. Reading for pleasure reduces stress, stimulates imagination, improves empathy, and enriches one's understanding of different cultures and experiences. Regular recreational reading also contributes significantly to vocabulary development and language fluency.

Figure 1.2: Purposes of Reading



Types of Reading

Reading can broadly be divided into **reading aloud** and **silent reading**, each serving different purposes.

Reading Aloud

Reading aloud, also known as loud reading, is especially common during the early stages of language learning. In this method, readers pronounce words clearly so that both they and others can hear them. Reading aloud improves pronunciation, stress patterns, rhythm, and intonation. It also helps learners become familiar with sentence structures and develops confidence in speaking before an audience. Teachers often use this method to assess students' pronunciation and fluency.

Silent Reading

Silent reading involves reading without speaking the words aloud. Most academic and professional reading is done silently because it is faster and allows greater concentration. Silent reading enables readers to focus entirely on understanding the meaning of the text. It improves comprehension, reading speed, memory, and independent learning. Since readers are not occupied with pronunciation, they can devote more attention to analysing ideas and interpreting information.

Table 1.1: Reading Aloud vs Silent Reading

Reading Aloud	Silent Reading
Words are spoken aloud	Words are read silently
Improves pronunciation	Improves comprehension
Suitable for beginners	Suitable for advanced reading
Develops speaking confidence	Increases reading speed
Used in classrooms	Used in academic and personal reading

Reading Strategies

Different reading situations require different strategies. Skilled readers adjust their reading method according to their purpose.

Skimming

Skimming is a rapid reading technique used to obtain a general understanding of a text without reading every word. The objective is to identify the main ideas rather than the finer details. Students often skim newspapers, magazines, websites, and textbook chapters before deciding whether to read them thoroughly.

When skimming, readers typically begin by examining the title, table of contents, headings, subheadings, introductory paragraph, and concluding section. They also pay attention to illustrations, graphs, and highlighted words. These elements provide an overview of the content and help readers predict the central ideas.

Steps in Skimming

1. Read the title carefully.
2. Examine the table of contents (if available).
3. Read the introduction or preface.
4. Look at headings and subheadings.
5. Read the first and last paragraphs.
6. Observe diagrams, illustrations, and highlighted terms.

Scanning

Scanning is another rapid reading strategy, but unlike skimming, its purpose is to locate specific information rather than gain a general understanding. Readers scan a text when searching for dates, names, definitions, page numbers, statistics, or particular facts.

For example, when using a dictionary, consulting a railway timetable, checking examination results, or searching for a phone number, people do not read every word. Instead, they quickly move their eyes across the page until they find the required information.

Scanning saves time and is especially useful in academic research and professional work where large amounts of information must be searched efficiently.

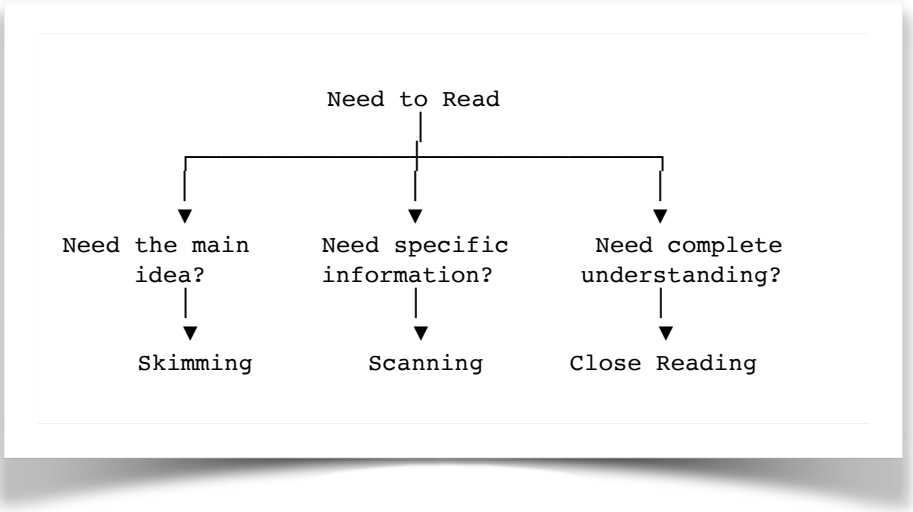
Close Reading

Close reading is the careful, detailed examination of a text. It requires readers to pay attention to every word, sentence, paragraph, and literary or argumentative device. Unlike skimming and scanning, close reading is slow and analytical.

Students use close reading when studying literary texts, analysing poems, interpreting novels, understanding research articles, or preparing for examinations. During close reading, readers ask questions, identify themes, examine vocabulary, interpret figurative language, evaluate evidence, and draw conclusions.

Close reading develops critical thinking and deep comprehension, making it one of the most valuable academic reading skills.

Figure 1.3: Choosing the Right Reading Strategy



Extensive and Intensive Reading

Another useful way to classify reading is by the amount and purpose of the material being read.

Extensive Reading

Extensive reading involves reading large quantities of material for general understanding or enjoyment. Readers are not expected to analyse every sentence in detail. Instead, they focus on understanding the overall meaning and enjoying the reading experience.

Books such as novels, biographies, travel writing, magazines, and popular science texts are often read extensively. Regular extensive reading improves reading fluency, increases vocabulary naturally, enhances comprehension, and builds confidence.

Intensive Reading

Intensive reading is the careful study of shorter texts in order to understand every important detail. Readers examine vocabulary, grammar, sentence structure, and meaning closely. This method is widely used in language learning and academic study.

Teachers frequently ask students to read passages intensively so that they can answer comprehension questions, analyse language, and understand complex ideas.

Table 1.2: Extensive Reading vs Intensive Reading

Extensive Reading	Intensive Reading
Long texts	Short texts
Reading for pleasure or general understanding	Reading for detailed understanding
Faster reading	Slower reading
Focus on overall meaning	Focus on language and details
Builds fluency	Builds accuracy

Importance of Reading Skills

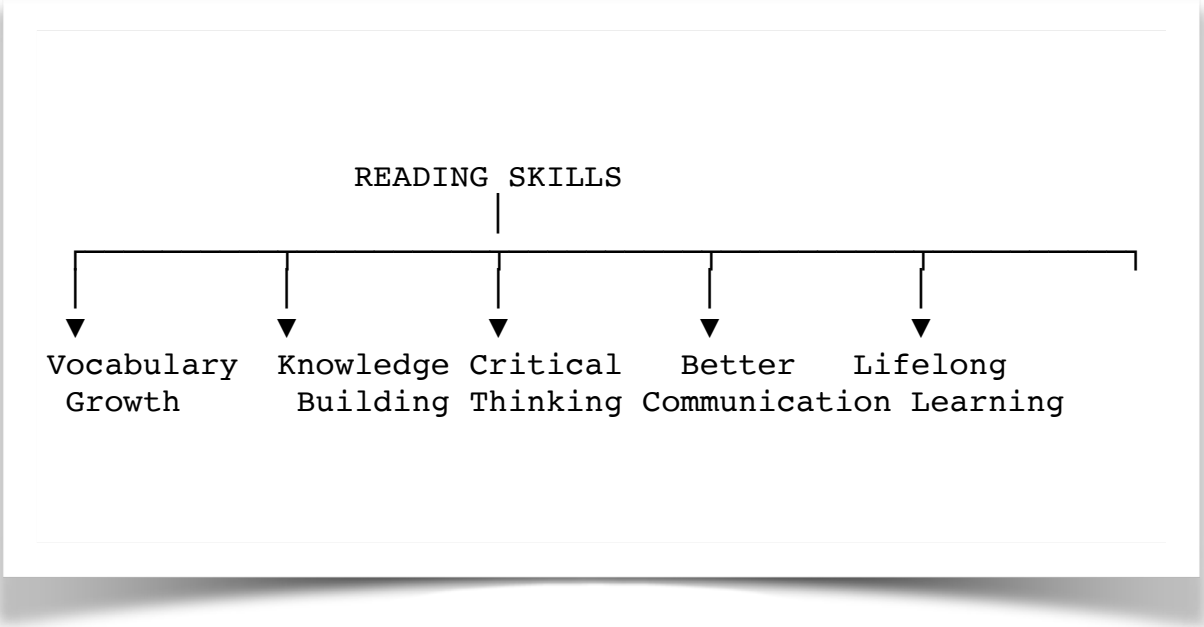
Reading is one of the most important skills for academic success and lifelong learning. Every subject—from literature and history to science and business—requires students to understand written information. Strong reading skills enable learners to acquire knowledge independently and think critically about what they read.

Effective reading improves vocabulary because readers encounter new words in different contexts. It enhances grammar and sentence construction by exposing learners to correct language use. Reading also develops critical thinking by encouraging readers to analyse evidence, compare viewpoints, identify assumptions, and evaluate arguments.

Furthermore, reading strengthens communication skills. People who read regularly generally express themselves more clearly in both speech and writing. Reading also promotes creativity, empathy, and cultural awareness by introducing readers to diverse experiences and perspectives.

Ultimately, reading transforms students into independent learners who can continue acquiring knowledge throughout their lives.

Figure 1.4: Benefits of Reading



Summary

Reading is a dynamic process of constructing meaning from written texts. It involves understanding, interpreting, analysing, and evaluating information rather than merely recognizing words. People read for various purposes, including gaining information, communicating, following instructions, and enjoying literature. Different situations require different reading strategies such as **skimming**, **scanning**, and **close reading**, while **extensive** and **intensive** reading serve different educational and personal goals.

Developing effective reading skills enhances vocabulary, comprehension, critical thinking, and communication. These skills not only support academic achievement but also prepare individuals for lifelong learning and informed participation in society. A skilled reader is therefore not simply someone who reads quickly, but someone who reads thoughtfully, purposefully, and critically.